

■■■ Chelyabinsk ≡ December 23, 2011

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Environmentalists : Mayak continues to dump radioactive waste into the Techa River

"The total amount of radioactive waste that entered the river could reach 500 million cubic meters."

Moscow environmentalists have released a document confirming the dumping of radioactive waste from the Mayak Production Association into the Techa River in the 2000s.

As the press service of the Ecodefense! group told Novy Region, according to the official position of the state corporation Rosatom, the discharge of liquid radioactive waste into the Techa River by the Mayak plant ceased in the 1950s, and for many years the enterprise has been operating in accordance with radiation and environmental safety standards.

However, environmentalists have managed to obtain a document proving otherwise. It is a court ruling in the criminal case against former Mayak director Vitaly Sadovnikov, dated May 11, 2006. This document cites unambiguous evidence of "fresh" radioactive contamination within the settlements located downstream of the Techa River.

According to the court ruling, between 2001 and 2004, approximately 30-40 million cubic meters of radioactive waste entered the Techa River, "resulting in radioactive contamination of the environment with the isotope strontium-90." The document states that measurements of the river near the village of Muslyumovo showed that the river water, according to sanitary regulations, "belonged to the category of liquid radioactive waste" (Section 3.3 of the Sanitary Rules for the Handling of Radioactive Waste (SPORO-2002)).

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The court ruling names five settlements within whose boundaries radioactive contamination due to Mayak's recent discharges has been detected: Muslyumovo, Brodokalmak, Russkaya Techa, Nizhnepetropavlovskoye, and Zatechenskoye. "This completely contradicts Rosatom's official position on the safety of residents in these villages," the activists state.

According to environmentalists, this is the first time in history that absolute proof of radioactive contamination of the environment has been obtained following discharges from Mayak, dating back to the 21st century, and not the distant 1950s.

Previously, it was only known that approximately 76 million cubic meters of radioactive wastewater were discharged into the Techa River from 1949 to 1956. It has now been revealed that another 30-40 million were discharged between 2001 and 2004. It is unknown how much was discharged in the last 40 years of the 20th century. According to the group "Ecodefense!", the total amount of radioactive waste actually discharged into the Techa River may be as high as 500 million cubic meters.

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Human rights activists note that the radioactive substances have not disappeared and are still present in the river: "Their penetration into the river water, apparently, continues on a continuous basis right up to this day."

In November of this year, Ecodefense experts measured gamma radiation levels on the banks of the Techa River near Muslyumovo. The dosimeter measured 1,586 microrentgens per hour, compared to the standard of 20. This means the radiation level exceeded the "normal" level by 79 times. Meanwhile, residents continue to use the river's water for personal and agricultural use—approximately 4,000-5,000 people live along the banks of the Techa.

Отметим, в апреле 2010 года группа «Экозащита!» и 23 жителя села Муслюмово направили в Замоскворецкий суд Москвы иск к правительству России, «Росатому», МЧС и Минздравсоцразвитию. Истцы требуют признать Течу «пунктом хранения радиоактивных отходов» и построить саркофаг, протяженностью около 240 километров, чтобы полностью закрыть доступ к радиоактивной реке. Рассмотрение этого иска продолжается до сих пор.

Челябинск, Юлия Малецкая

Челябинск. Другие новости 23.12.11

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